

REALISM PROMPTING FORMULAS

The Complete Positive & Negative Prompt Engineering System for Forcing Photographic Realism in AI Image Generation

Version 1.1 · April 2025 — Corrected Edition

For use with: AuthenticLens — The Realism Architect Gemini Gem
Confidential Reference Document

■ ERRATA — GLOBAL CORRECTIONS FOR DOC 3

1. The universal negative prompt has been revised. The original blocked 'professional photography', 'sharp', and 'vibrant' — these are too blunt and suppress legitimate real-photo qualities. New targeted negatives replace these. 2. A new Section 5 covers Gemini / Nano Banana prompting architecture, which was entirely absent. 3. Platform section previously covered only Midjourney, Stable Diffusion, DALL-E, and Firefly. Gemini is the target platform and now has a dedicated execution section.

SECTION 1 — THE REALISM PROMPTING PHILOSOPHY

AI image generators are trained on vast datasets that include both photographic images and digitally created artwork. Without specific guidance, models default to a 'median aesthetic' that blends photographic and rendered qualities — the result is the AI look: hyper-smooth, perfectly lit, slightly surreal. Forcing genuine photorealism requires a two-pronged approach: actively injecting photographic language that anchors the model to real camera physics, and actively suppressing the vocabulary of rendered, studio, and AI aesthetics.

Prompt engineering for realism operates at five levels simultaneously:

- Technical photography parameters (camera model, lens, aperture, film stock)
- Contextual realism signals (shooting scenario, time of day, weather, social context)
- Imperfection injection (grain, blur, noise, flare)
- Anti-AI suppressors (targeted negative prompts that block AI aesthetic tendencies without blocking real-photo qualities)

- Style reference anchors (specific photographers, publications, or photographic eras)
■ *NOTE: The most powerful realism signals are specific rather than generic. '35mm film photograph' is weaker than '35mm photograph on Kodak Portra 400, shot with a Nikon FM2, f/2.8, 1/250s, slightly underexposed by 1/3 stop.'* Specificity signals the model to activate its photographic knowledge at maximum precision.

SECTION 2 — THE MASTER POSITIVE KEYWORD LIBRARY

2.1 — PHOTOGRAPHIC AUTHENTICITY ANCHORS

These terms establish the fundamental photographic context and activate the model's photographic knowledge domain.

Positive Keywords (Use)	Negative Keywords (Avoid)
photograph, photo, photography	digital art, artwork, illustration
shot on film, candid photograph	concept art, render, CGI, 3D render
documentary photo, photojournalism	digital painting, drawing, cartoon, anime
street photography, reportage	comic, graphic novel, game art
editorial photography, snapshot	character art, cinematic render
found footage, archival photo	hyperrealistic render, 8K render
analog photograph, film photography	octane render, unreal engine, blender
unedited, raw photograph, authentic	artstation, deviantart
real person, candid, unstaged	zbrush, subsurface scattering (as keyword)
photographic, camera photograph	

2.2 — CAMERA AND TECHNICAL SPECIFICATION PROMPTS

Specifying real camera models, lenses, and technical parameters forces the model to simulate the characteristic optical properties of that equipment.

Era / Type	Camera Models	Characteristic Aesthetic
Vintage 35mm SLR	Nikon FM2, Canon AE-1, Pentax K1000, Olympus OM-1	Mechanical precision, slight vignetting, classic film grain
Modern 35mm SLR	Nikon F6, Canon EOS-1V, Minolta Maxxum 9	Contemporary film rendering, accurate colour
Medium Format Film	Hasselblad 500C/M, Mamiya RZ67, Rolleiflex 2.8F	Rich tonality, ultra-fine grain, square format
Professional Digital	Canon 5D Mark IV, Nikon D850, Sony A7R IV	Modern DSLR/mirrorless aesthetic, clinical sharpness

Era / Type	Camera Models	Characteristic Aesthetic
Vintage Rangefinder	Leica M6, Leica M3, Voigtlander Bessa	Documentary feel, slight softness, intimate framing
Disposable Camera	Kodak FunSaver, Fujifilm QuickSnap	Flash-lit foreground, grainy, washed-out colours
Polaroid	Polaroid SX-70, Polaroid 600, Instax Wide	Soft, dreamy, overexposed edges
Phone Camera (vintage)	Nokia N95, iPhone 3G, early smartphone	Low resolution, noise, narrow dynamic range

2.3 — FILM STOCK SPECIFICATION PROMPTS

Film Stock	Prompt String	Colour / Aesthetic Result
Kodak Portra 400	"shot on Kodak Portra 400"	Warm skin tones, creamy highlights, fine grain, excellent latitude
Kodak Portra 800	"shot on Kodak Portra 800"	Warmer, slightly more grain, generous latitude in low light
Kodak Ektar 100	"shot on Kodak Ektar 100"	Vivid, punchy colours, ultra-fine grain, saturated blues and greens
Kodak Gold 200	"shot on Kodak Gold 200"	Classic golden warmth, consumer film aesthetic, slightly hazy
Fujifilm Pro 400H	"shot on Fujifilm Pro 400H"	Cool, desaturated pastels, flattering skin, natural greens
Fujifilm Velvia 50	"shot on Fujifilm Velvia 50"	Hyper-saturated, punchy contrast, landscape/nature aesthetic
Ilford HP5 Plus	"shot on Ilford HP5 Plus, black and white"	Classic B&W;, medium grain, wide tonal range
Kodak T-MAX 3200	"shot on Kodak T-MAX P3200, pushed"	High-grain B&W;, gritty, high contrast
Cinestill 800T	"shot on Cinestill 800T"	Red halation on bright lights, tungsten balance, cinematic

2.4 — IMPERFECTION AND AUTHENTICITY INJECTION PROMPTS

Positive (Inject These)	Revised Negatives (Targeted — see Section 2.5)
film grain, visible grain, ISO noise	waxy skin, plastic skin, poreless cheeks
chromatic aberration, colour fringing	fake bokeh cutout, excessive lens flare
lens vignette, corner vignetting	impossible shadows, floating subject

Positive (Inject These)	Revised Negatives (Targeted — see Section 2.5)
lens flare (justified only)	melted fabric, unreadable logos
motion blur, camera shake, slight blur	synthetic glow, AI glow
shallow depth of field, bokeh	overdone HDR, crushed blacks (unless requested)
natural lighting, available light, mixed lighting	identity drift
skin texture, skin pores, natural skin	garbled branding, counterfeit-looking logos
wrinkles, freckles, blemishes, sweat	over-smoothing halos, over-sharpening halos
overexposed, slightly underexposed, blown highlights	
dust on lens, sensor dust, light leak	

2.5 — REVISED UNIVERSAL NEGATIVE PROMPT

■ ERRATA — CORRECTION — UNIVERSAL NEGATIVE	ORIGINAL universal negative blocked: 'professional photography, sharp, vibrant.' These terms are too blunt — real photos can be professional, sharp, and vibrant. The revised targeted negatives below replace the original universal block.
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REVISED TARGETED NEGATIVE PROMPT — Group by failure type, not one giant block:

Identity and Skin	waxy skin, plastic skin, poreless cheeks, extreme airbrushing, doll-like face, identity drift, face change
Anatomy	warped hands, fused fingers, extra digits, distorted limbs, impossible joints
Fabric and Clothing	melted fabric, random wrinkles, floating hems, fake seam lines, gravity-defying drape
Light and Shadow	inconsistent shadows, floating subject, mismatched light direction, fake rim light, synthetic glow, AI glow
Background	synthetic-looking background, wrong scale, mismatched perspective, incorrect horizon
Optical Failures	fake bokeh cutout, excessive lens flare, overused chromatic aberration
Text and Logos	unreadable text, garbled logos, counterfeit-looking luxury branding, pseudo-alphabetic text
Processing	over-smoothing, over-sharpening halos, overdone HDR, extreme tone-mapping, render, CGI, 3D, digital art, illustration, anime, artstation

2.6 — CONTEXTUAL REALISM SIGNALS

Positive Context (Use)	Negative Context (Avoid)
candid, street photography, documentary	studio shoot, professional photo shoot

Positive Context (Use)	Negative Context (Avoid)
photojournalism, reportage, paparazzi shot	model shoot, lookbook photo
tourist photo, vacation snapshot, family photo	commercial photography, controlled environment
party photo, concert photography, sports	posed, staged, directed
amateur snapshot, selfie, mirror selfie	fine art photo, gallery photography
CCTV footage, security camera, surveillance	award-winning photography, exhibition photo
home video still, found footage, classified ad	
passport photo, ID photo, yearbook photo	
crime scene photo, archival, historical photograph	

SECTION 3 — MASTER PROMPT FORMULAS BY SCENARIO

3.1 — PORTRAIT PHOTOGRAPHY MASTER PROMPTS

Formula A: Natural Light Street Portrait (Reportage Style)

POSITIVE: [SUBJECT DESCRIPTION], candid portrait, unposed, documentary photography, shot on 35mm film, Nikon FM2, 50mm f/1.8 lens, wide open aperture, available light, overcast diffuse light, natural skin texture, visible pores, slight film grain, shot on Kodak Portra 400, shallow depth of field, background out of focus, slight chromatic aberration, natural expression, unstaged, urban environment, photojournalism, unretouched

NEGATIVE: waxy skin, plastic skin, poreless cheeks, fake bokeh cutout, synthetic glow, AI glow, render, CGI, over-smoothing, identity drift, garbled logos, impossible shadows

Formula B: Intimate Indoor Low-Light Portrait

POSITIVE: [SUBJECT DESCRIPTION], intimate portrait, low light indoor photography, single window light source camera left, warm tungsten ambient fill, shot on Fujifilm Pro 400H, 85mm f/1.4 lens, visible grain, slight motion blur from hand-holding, skin texture visible, natural imperfections, slightly desaturated background, real skin, natural expression, personal documentary

NEGATIVE: waxy skin, doll face, AI glow, identity drift, over-smoothing, overdone HDR

Formula C: Gritty Street Portrait (High Grain)

POSITIVE: [SUBJECT DESCRIPTION], street portrait, high contrast black and white, shot on Ilford HP5 Plus pushed to ISO 1600, Leica M6 rangefinder, 35mm Summicron lens, grainy, harsh shadows, available light, slightly underexposed, crushed blacks, high contrast, documentary photography

NEGATIVE: AI glow, plastic skin, render, CGI, digital painting, overdone HDR, identity drift

3.2 — STREET AND URBAN PHOTOGRAPHY MASTER PROMPTS

Formula A: Contemporary Urban Street Photography

POSITIVE: [SCENE DESCRIPTION], street photography, candid, unposed bystanders, shot on Sony A7III, 28mm f/2.8 lens, ISO 1600, slight noise, available light, mixed colour temperature (warm tungsten signs, cool daylight), slight motion blur on moving figures, lens vignette at corners, real urban grit, wet pavement reflections with Fresnel fall-off, chromatic aberration on high-contrast edges, photojournalism

NEGATIVE: render, CGI, floating subject, impossible shadows, synthetic-looking background, garbled signage

Formula B: Night Street / Neon Photography

POSITIVE: [SCENE DESCRIPTION], night street photography, neon lights, shot on Cinestill 800T, 35mm f/2 lens, red halation on neon signs, tungsten colour balance giving blue cast to ambient, grainy, high ISO noise, long exposure motion blur on pedestrians, wet street reflections, glare on camera lens, underexposed shadows, neon colour bleeding

NEGATIVE: AI glow, fake rim light, overdone HDR, render, CGI, garbled signage

3.3 — FASHION AND COMMERCIAL EDITORIAL PROMPTS

Formula A: Editorial Fashion (Anti-Commercial)

POSITIVE: [SUBJECT + FASHION DESCRIPTION], editorial fashion photography, not commercial, photojournalistic approach, natural light from skylight, shot on medium format film, Hasselblad 500C/M, 80mm f/2.8 Planar lens, Kodak Portra 400, medium grain, natural skin texture, candid during fitting, behind-the-scenes quality, unretouched, imperfect background, raw feeling

NEGATIVE: waxy skin, AI glow, melted fabric, fake seam lines, garbled logos, identity drift, overdone HDR

3.4 — DOCUMENTARY AND ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPHY PROMPTS

POSITIVE: [SCENE DESCRIPTION], documentary photograph, archival quality, [DECADE e.g. '1970s'], photojournalism, shot on [era-appropriate camera], aged film, slight fading, colour shift toward magenta/yellow, grain consistent with period film stocks, authentic period environment, candid subjects unaware of camera, natural imperfections

NEGATIVE: render, CGI, overdone HDR, identity drift, synthetic glow, garbled text

SECTION 4 — PLATFORM-SPECIFIC PROMPTING STRATEGIES

4.1 — MIDJOURNEY REALISM STRATEGIES

Positive Parameters / Keywords	Negative Parameters / Keywords to Avoid
--style raw (disables Midjourney aesthetic enhancement)	--style expressive (increases AI aesthetics)
--ar 2:3 or --ar 3:2 (simulates 35mm aspect ratio)	--s 700-1000 (heavy stylization — avoid)
--s 0 to 100 (stylize: lower = more literal)	"beautiful", "stunning", "masterpiece"
--q 1 (quality: faster, sometimes grainier)	"cinematic lighting" (adds AI-rendered look)
--chaos 20-40 (increases natural disorder)	"detailed", "intricate" (triggers render aesthetic)
"photo" at the start of prompt	"trending on artstation" (strong AI art trigger)
"natural light, available light"	"hyperrealistic" (paradoxically renders, not photographs)
Reference image URL of real documentary photo	"8K resolution" (triggers render aesthetic)

Midjourney Realism Master Prompt:

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/imagine photo [subject description], candid, documentary photography, shot on [camera model], [film stock], [aperture], available light, film grain, imperfect, unposed --style raw --ar 2:3 --s 50 --q 1
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4.2 — STABLE DIFFUSION / AUTOMATIC1111 STRATEGIES

Parameter	Recommended Value	Reasoning
Sampler	DPM++ 2M Karras	Balanced quality and detail without over-rendering
Steps	25–35	Sufficient convergence without over-processing
CFG Scale	5–7	Lower CFG reduces over-saturation and sharpening
Denoise Strength	0.45–0.65 (img2img)	Preserves structure while allowing correction
Resolution	512x768 or 768x1024	Native SD resolution; upscale after with ESRGAN
Hires Fix	Enabled, 2x upscale	Adds high-frequency detail post-generation
Clip Skip	1 or 2	1 for realism checkpoints; 2 for anime-origin models

4.3 — DALL-E 3 STRATEGIES

DALL-E 3 is instruction-following rather than keyword-driven. Use full descriptive sentences.

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Generate a photograph – not a rendering, illustration, or digital artwork – of [SUBJECT DESCRIPTION]. This should look like it was taken with a [CAMERA MODEL]
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camera using a [LENS] lens at f/[APERTURE], shot on [FILM STOCK]. The image should have visible film grain, natural skin texture with visible pores, and realistic imperfect lighting from [LIGHT SOURCE]. Avoid waxy skin, synthetic glow, impossible shadows, garbled text, and any rendered or illustrated quality. The photograph should look candid and authentic.

4.4 — ADOBE FIREFLY STRATEGIES

- Use 'Content Type: Photo' setting before prompting.
- Deselect all visual intensity and effect presets.
- Use the 'Reference image' upload feature with real documentary photographs.
- Avoid Firefly's 'Generative Match' features — they tend toward stock aesthetics.

POSITIVE: documentary photograph, candid, film grain, available light, natural skin, authentic, [film stock name], [camera model], photojournalism

NEGATIVE: waxy skin, AI glow, synthetic glow, melted fabric, garbled logos, identity drift, render, CGI, overdone HDR

SECTION 5 — GEMINI AND NANO BANANA PROMPTING (NEW)

This section was absent from the original Document 3. Gemini / Nano Banana (Gemini 3.1 Flash Image / Gemini 3 Pro Image) is the primary target platform for the AuthenticLens Gem. These models are instruction-following systems that respond to structured, descriptive language. Full execution architecture is in Document 6.

Key Differences from Legacy Parameter Models:

- DO NOT use keyword lists or parameter flags (--style raw, --s 50). Gemini does not support these.
- Use complete, structured sentences. Describe intent, constraints, physics, and desired outcome.
- Use modular prompt blocks (task command + preservation + subject + scene + lighting + texture + negative).
- Prefer targeted local edits over global regeneration.
- Use conversational iteration — issue corrections in follow-up messages.
- Include explicit self-check instructions: 'Before finalising, verify face consistency, shadow grounding, and fabric realism.'

Gemini Quick Prompt Structure:

[TASK]: Enhance this image for photographic realism only.
[PRESERVATION]: Do not change the person's face, age, skin tone family, hairstyle, body proportions, clothing, or background.
[SUBJECT]: Keep the same person, pose, and expression exactly.
[LIGHTING]: Match soft overcast daylight from camera left.
[TEXTURE]: Restore natural skin pores, believable fabric weave, realistic hair edges.
[STYLE]: Subtle editorial correction only. Avoid dramatic stylisation.

[NEGATIVE]: No waxy skin, no warped hands, no fake logos, no synthetic glow, no impossible shadows.
[QC]: Before finalising, verify face consistency, shadow grounding, fabric realism, and readable text.

Gemini Negative Constraints (Targeted — not a blunt list):

Use grouped negative instructions. See Document 6 Negative Instruction Library for the full system. Never block 'professional photography', 'sharp', or 'vibrant' — real photos can legitimately be all three.

SECTION 6 — PHASE 2 POST-PROCESSING PROTOCOLS (PHOTOSHOP / LIGHTROOM)

When Phase 2 requires modifying an existing image rather than regenerating, apply the following protocols ordered from highest to lowest impact on perceived authenticity.

Priority	Modification	Tool / Method	Settings / Notes
1 — CRITICAL	Film Grain Addition	PS: Filter > Noise > Add Noise	Amount: 8–20 depending on target ISO. Gaussian, Monochromatic, then duplicate at 50% for colour noise.
2 — CRITICAL	Skin Texture Addition	PS: High-pass at 2–4px on skin layer, Blend: Overlay 30–50%	Use Texture overlay from real skin reference. Reduces AI plastic quality.
3 — HIGH	Chromatic Aberration	PS: Split channels, offset R +0.5px, B -0.5px from centre	Apply radially from image centre. Most visible at corners and edges.
4 — HIGH	Vignette	LR: Effects > Vignette, Midpoint ~40, Roundness -20	Amount: -25 to -45. Subtle and organic.
5 — HIGH	Highlight Clipping	LR: Highlights -80 to -100, Whites +20	Creates realistic film highlight rolloff. Slightly blow out specular highlights.
6 — MEDIUM	Shadow Blocking	LR: Shadows -30 to -60, Blacks -20	Crushes some shadow detail to simulate film's limited shadow latitude.
7 — MEDIUM	Colour Cast	LR: White Balance shift ±200K, Tint ±5	Avoid perfect neutral white balance. Real photos have casts.
8 — MEDIUM	Lens Distortion	PS: Filter > Lens Correction, barrel distortion +5 to +20	Simulate wide-angle barrel distortion for interior/wide shots.
9 — LOW	Lens Flare	PS: Filter > Render > Lens Flare	Only if a light source is present in frame. 105mm Prime flare type.

Priority	Modification	Tool / Method	Settings / Notes
10 — LOW	Motion Blur (selective)	PS: Motion Blur on background layer	Direction: horizontal $\pm 5^\circ$. Amount: 2–8px. Background elements only.

SECTION 7 — QUICK REFERENCE CHEAT SHEETS

7.1 — THE 10-WORD REALISM PROMPT (EMERGENCY FORMULA)

[subject], candid, 35mm film, Kodak Portra 400, grain, available light, skin texture, unposed, f/2.8, vignette

7.2 — THE AUTHENTICLENS PHASE 2 GENERATION PROMPT STRUCTURE

[CONTENT TYPE: 'photograph' or 'photo of'] [SUBJECT + ENVIRONMENT + ACTION (specific, grounded description)] [CAMERA BODY: specific model] + [LENS: focal length + aperture] [FILM STOCK or SENSOR] + [ISO value] [LIGHTING: natural source + direction + quality] [IMPERFECTIONS: grain/noise + CA + vignette + any motion] [CONTEXT: photographic genre + social context] [STYLE REFERENCE: photographer or publication]

NEGATIVE: [Targeted negatives from Section 2.5 – group by failure type]